

## Progress of the Peace Talks

**Open, or “plenary” talks, with permanent delegations from all the participants had got underway in Paris by 1972. These proceeded alongside secret talks involving Henry Kissinger for the United States and Le Duc Tho for North Vietnam.**

### ◀◀ BEFORE

**Tentative negotiations to end the war had consistently failed as a result of the conflicting positions of both sides.**

#### **SOUTH VIETNAMESE CONCERNS**

The Thieu **government’s objectives** were the removal of North Vietnamese forces from the South, the disarming of the Viet Cong, and securing the continued leadership of Thieu.

#### **OPPOSING MOTIVES**

The major concern of the North was to secure a **total withdrawal of the US** from South Vietnam, ensuring the Viet Cong was brought into the Saigon government, and, if possible, ousting President Thieu.



ANTIWAR BUTTON

**B**y 1972, it had become clear that any progress in Vietnam peace talks would have to come from the meetings between Henry Kissinger and Le Duc Tho, which left out the intensely wary South Vietnamese. Although the US played its hand very close to its chest, the South Vietnamese received periodic updates. After January, when President Nixon revealed the existence of the secret talks, public pressure to reach an agreement grew more intense.

The negotiators met in Paris on May 2. The North Vietnamese refused to call off their offensive and the US negotiators rejected a proposal to unseat President Thieu. With the peace talks in a state of deadlock, the next scheduled discussion was cancelled.

### **Breaking the deadlock**

During a summit with the Russians in Moscow, Nixon sent the North Vietnamese another message via Soviet hands—that a commission that would be created to carry out a new presidential election in the South could function as an interim coalition government. That proposal interested the North Vietnamese, and meetings on July 19 and August 1 began to break the deadlock. The US agreed to include both political and military elements in an